Christian D. Castaño Bonilla, MS, MPP

Researcher in economics and political economy

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Summary

Economics and political science researcher with expertise in data science, impact evaluation, causal inference, and psychometrics. Interested in public economics and political economy. Work experience across four continents for institutions like the World Bank, UNODC, and top universities. Adept in data analysis, machine learning, and NLP tools, with strong quantitative rigor and cross-cultural fluency in research and implementation. Native Spanish and English, intermediate Italian, basic French.

Education

Universidad Icesi | Cali, Colombia

MPP in Government and Public Policy

- GPA 4.68/5.0 (Distinction)
- Final project approved without corrections

Universitat de Barcelona | Barcelona, Spain

MS in Institutions and Political Economy

- GPA 8.7/10 (Distinction)
- Thesis 9.6/10
- Honor roll
- Ambassador

Universidad Icesi | Cali, Colombia

Project Management Certificate Course

University of Iowa | Iowa, USA

BBA in Management & Minor in International Relations

- GPA 3.47/4
- Dean's list

Work Experience

The World Bank | Washington, DC, USA

Research Analyst - Development Impact Group — February 2025 – Present

- Build novel datasets of non-tariff measures (NTMs) using NLP, collaborating with UNCTAD.
- Produce global trade time-series visualizations featured in the World Development Report.
- Co-author research papers and policy briefs on the effects of NTMs on international trade.
- Generate compact reproducibility packages to construct panel data with 470M+ observations.

Research Coordinator - Africa Gender Innovation Lab — January 2025 – Present

- Coordinated the MAGNET initiative's research operations, including liaising with researchers, partner institutions, and field teams across multiple countries.
- Co-authored gender-focused research papers analyzing bias and measurement reliability.
- Led updates to the website and external communications to support dissemination and visibility.
- Pursued opportunities for uptake of MAGNET tools by partner institutions and researchers.

Research Assistant - Africa Gender Innovation Lab — July 2023 – December 2024

- Conducted psychometric validation of women's empowerment and agency tools using STATA.
- Authored technical documentation and publication-ready content on MAGNET tool design.
- Prepared household surveys with CAPI for use in sub-Saharan Africa & Asia with multiple partners.
- Ran analysis and frequency checks on survey tools and lab-in-the-field data to monitor quality.

Universitat de Barcelona | Barcelona, Spain

Research Assistant - Development Economics — December 2022 – July 2023

- Applied machine learning methods to estimate CATE in randomized controlled trials.
- Leveraged Causal Forest algorithms to analyze heterogeneous treatment effects.
- Wrangled data to combine several databases with tens of thousands of observations.

Regional Academy on the United Nations | Vienna, Austria

Research Fellow - UN Office on Drugs and Crime — June 2022 – January 2023

- Analyzed cross-national drug policy legislation using Natural Language Processing (NLP) techniques.
- Collected survey data from experts on transparency and governance in drug treatment systems.
- Presented actionable proposals to address corruption and rights violations in treatment systems.

Skills & Abilities

- English/Spanish – Native
- French/Italian – Basic
- Intercultural Skills
- Psychometrics & Econometrics
- Data Analysis (R & STATA)
- Survey Solutions & SurveyCTO
- Text Analysis (NLP)
- Machine Learning
- GIS

Working papers & Presentations

Castaño Bonilla, C., Doss, C., and Hernandez-de-Benito, M. 2026. *The Role of Enumerators' views on gender in shaping respondents' answers.* Unpublished manuscript. World Bank.

Castaño Bonilla, C., Donald, A., Jain, M., and Raj A. 2026. *Measuring Implicit Bias Toward Gender-Incongruent Occupations in Uganda and India.* Unpublished manuscript. World Bank.

Cervantes Nieto, A. and **Castaño Bonilla, C.** 2024. *Transparency and governance in drug treatment systems: A comparative framework*. London School of Economics. Corruption and Conflicts of Interest in Healthcare (INET)

Cervantes Nieto, A. and **Castaño Bonilla, C**. 2023. *Transparency and governance in drug treatment systems: A comparative framework*. University of Barcelona. Interdisciplinary Corruption Research Forum (ICRN)

Cervantes Nieto, A. and **Castaño Bonilla, C**. 2023. *Corruption in drug treatment systems, innovation against corrupt practices.* United Nations Vienna International Centre. Regional Academy on the United Nations

References

- **Maria Hernandez-de-Benito, PhD:**
  Assistant Tenure Track Professor (Economics) - CUNEF Universidad

- **Elisabetta Aurino, PhD:**
  Tenure Track Professor (Development Economics) - Universitat de Barcelona

- **Alfonso Herranz-Loncan, PhD:**
  Director of the Economics and Economic History Research Center - Universitat de Barcelona